

Spring 2026 Introduction to Philosophy DND

Addendum

Overall Course Setup

- **Group Structure:** By the second week, students form small groups of **5 members** each.
- **Rotating Dungeon Master (DM) Role:** Every group member gets **one turn** to act as the Dungeon Master (DM) for a full session/day.
 - This distributes workload fairly—no one is stuck doing all the prep.
 - The DM takes ownership of that day’s reading/topic, transforming it into a D&D-style adventure. The D&D assignment is not exactly like D&D though I’ve tried to keep it as close as possible. The idea is to encourage students to talk through the philosophical issues we read about.

Ideally you begin by imagining being in a unique situation that makes you question some belief that you’ve always taken for granted.

Each day that we do the activity, each group will have a new DM for that day. The DM rolls the dice to set the difficulty class. They then read the encounter.

- There are billions of people (non sims) in the actual universe.
- Therefore there will be billions of *sim* people in the sim universe.
- Such a program, the *simUniverse*, will likely be very successful and there will be many, many *simUniverses* sold.

Therefore there will be many more sims than non sims.

Encounter

The DM then reads an imagined context that motivates each of the reasons above in a turn based format.

Going around the table, the DM has each member of their group roll a d20 to determine what position on one of the reasons above, they are going to take. Do they defend the reason given, or do they critique it?

First, as a class we take three polls, one for each reason. Is there more who agree with the reason above, or disagree with it?

Next,

- The DM rolls a dice and gets 10.

Winning roll:

- If the other student rolls higher, they get to defend the intuitive position.
- This is whichever position there is most agreement for.

Losing roll:

- If the other student rolls lower than the DM, then they will have to defend the least likely answer.
- The position with the least agreement for.

The students give their position which is recorded onto everyone's tally sheets. At the end of the campaign for that day, each sheet should have a set of positions for each of the reasons above, either defending it, or objecting to it, one from each member of the group.

Everyone should have their own copy of the tally sheet. You will upload a photo of it to Canvas under the assignment module. You keep the tally sheet for the entire semester.

Session Format (When a Student is DM)

1. Presentation of the Reading

The DM presents the assigned philosophical text (e.g., a reading on justice, legal positivism, natural law, authority, rights, punishment, or core intro topics like knowledge/reality) **structured as a D&D adventure**.

- Think narrative framing: The group is a party of adventurers (or avatars embodying philosophical positions).
- The reading becomes the “quest” or “dungeon” backdrop—e.g., a moral/legal dilemma in a kingdom, a trial in a courtroom-cave, or a riddle posed by a sphinx representing a philosopher.

2. Challenges Presented One at a Time

The DM introduces **several challenges** sequentially (like encounters in a dungeon).

- Each challenge draws directly from key concepts, arguments, objections, or thought experiments in the reading.
- Examples:
 - A village demands obedience to an unjust law → Debate duty to obey.
 - A trial with conflicting evidence → Explore legal interpretation or epistemology of testimony.
 - A trolley-like scenario in a fantasy context → Apply ethics/law theories.

3. Group Interaction & Participation

For **each challenge**:

- Any group member can respond by:
 - **Asking a clarifying question** about the challenge (probing the text/concept).
 - **Offering a suggestion/solution** (proposing a philosophical position, argument, or counter).
- The DM evaluates the response in character (as the “world” reacting).
 - The responding player **rolls dice** (typically a d20 + relevant modifier, like “Intelligence for reasoning” or “Charisma for persuasion”) to determine the outcome/strength of their idea.
 - Success → Advances the “quest,” strengthens the argument, or reveals new insight.
 - Failure → Complication, objection, or setback (e.g., a logical fallacy is exposed).

4. Collaborative Input & Multiple Rolls

After the first response/roll:

- Other group members get turns to **offer their own responses** or build on/counter the previous one.
- They also **roll dice** to suggest “other considerations” (e.g., alternative interpretations, edge cases, or objections from the reading).
- This creates a back-and-forth discussion, with dice adding chance, excitement, and stakes—mirroring how philosophical debates involve risk, uncertainty, and persuasion.

5. Resolution & Reflection

- The DM adjudicates the collective outcomes (like a traditional DM).
- The session ends with debrief: How did the “adventure” illuminate the reading? What arguments won/lost? How does this apply to real philosophy of law or intro questions?

Why This Works for Philosophy (Especially Philosophy of Law)

- Turns abstract texts into experiential “living” philosophy—students defend positions, face consequences, and see ideas clash.
- Dice rolls simulate uncertainty in reasoning (e.g., a brilliant argument might “fail” due to poor delivery, or a flawed one succeed by luck—prompting reflection on persuasion vs. truth).
- Rotating DM role builds skills in presentation, facilitation, and creative application of ideas.
- Small groups (5) ensure everyone participates actively.

This structure is innovative but aligns with existing experiments in using D&D/RPGs to teach philosophy (e.g., ethics courses with group quests or

embodying philosophers as characters). It keeps sessions engaging, hands-on, and true to the spirit of philosophical inquiry as a shared adventure in reasoning! If you'd like examples of challenges for specific topics (e.g., Hart vs. Fuller on law, or Plato's *Republic* as a dungeon), let me know.

Examples

Examples of D&D-Style Challenges

These are **concrete examples** of challenges the DM for a given week may use. Each is designed for a **5-player group session** (45-60 minutes), drawing directly from key readings. The DM narrates in a immersive, fantasy voice, presents challenges **one at a time**, and adjudicates dice rolls (e.g., d20 + "Wisdom" for insight, "Charisma" for persuasion).

- **Success thresholds:** DC 10-15 (easy for basic grasp, hard for nuance). High roll = insight/reward; low = complication/objection.
- **Player actions:** Ask a question (probe text) or suggest a solution (defend position). Others chime in with counters/considerations.
- **Pre-gen characters:** Assign avatars like "The Skeptic" (epistemology focus) or "The Judge" (law focus) for roleplay.

I've structured them for **Philosophy of Law** (Hart vs. Fuller) and **Introduction to Philosophy** (Plato's *Republic* as a dungeon). Use a simple cheat sheet for DM notes.

Introduction to Philosophy: Plato's *Republic* (Justice & the Cave as Dungeon)

DM Setup Narrative: "You awaken chained in the Cave of Shadows—*Plato's Republic* unfolds as your prison. Flickering firelight casts puppet illusions on the wall: 'thrones,' 'wars,' 'gold.' A voice (Socrates) whispers: 'What is justice? Break free or stay comfy?' Your pre-gen avatars (Guardian, Philosopher, Artisan) must navigate to the sunlight exit."

Challenge #	Description (DM Presents)	Player Responses & Dice Outcomes
1: Defining Justice (Book I)	“A shadowy ‘thief’ steals from the ‘rich man’ illusion. The cave echoes: ‘Is justice helping friends or the stronger ruling?’ (Thrasymachus taunt).”	- Question: “What did Polemarchus/Cephalus say?” (Wisdom roll: 10+ → “Justice as repayment?” Low → Tricked by illusion.)- Suggestion: “Justice is soul harmony” (Plato tease). (Constitution roll: Success → Break one chain; Fail → Headache debuff.)- Others: Debate counters → Roll Perception for “shadow flaws.”
2: The Ideal City Escape (Books II-IV)	“To flee, build a ‘just city’ in the cave: Guardians train, producers craft. But corruption spreads—luxury tempts!”	- Question: “Why ban poetry/myths?” (Intelligence roll: 13+ → Purify city; Low → Demoralized party.)- Suggestion: “Philosopher-kings rule!” (Charisma roll: Success → Unlock tunnel; Fail → Faction revolt.)- Others: Add classes (waves, auxiliaries) → Group rolls scale city “health.”
3: Sunlight Revelation (Books VI-VII, Cave Allegory)	“You reach the exit: Blinding sun! Puppets were lies. Return to free others? They mock you as mad.”	- Question: “Forms vs. shadows—what’s real?” (Insight roll: 15+ → Vision quest boon; Low → Blinded retreat.)- Suggestion: “Descend as educators.” (Strength roll: Success → Convert prisoners; Fail → Stoned as heretic.)- Others: Resistance rolls → “Allegory boss”: High total → Party ascends enlightened.

DM Tips: Use printed “shadow puppets” (simple drawings) as props. Debrief: How does the Cave mirror epistemology? Link to course: “Roll d20: What is reality?”

These are **plug-and-play**—scale difficulty by reading depth. For more (e.g., Descartes’ evil demon as a trap room or Mill’s utilitarianism trolley trap), specify topics! This keeps sessions fun, fair, and deeply philosophical.